

CRACKING THE WHIP

Mayawati's promised crackdown on criminals has claimed some early successes. Dreaded dacoit Dadua is dead and some notorious criminals in politics are being made to run for cover.



■ **By Subhash Mishra**

As far as electoral promises go, Mayawati is in the happy position of keeping a few and also being seen as actively doing so. Barely two months after she took over as the chief minister of Uttar Pradesh, Mayawati's crackdown on crime, goondaraj and mafiaraj, is well under way.

Along with turning the heat on criminals with political connections, her big success has come in the form of the elimination of notorious dacoit Shiv Kumar Patel, aka Dadua. Along with nine of his gang members, Dadua was believed to have been responsible for more than 200 crimes including murder, looting and rape.

But within 24 hours of the operation that eliminated the scourge of a dozen districts on the Uttar Pradesh-Madhya Pradesh border, another gang of dacoits headed by Ambika Patel alias Thokia gunned down six jawans of the Special Task Force (STF). It was as if Thokia was staking claim to Dadua's brutal legacy.

Thokia has vowed to avenge the killing of his "bhaiya", and warned that the killings of the policemen were a precursor of bloody days to come. It is

VALOUR: STF jawans after killing Dadua and his gang members

clear now that the Government's drive against crime and criminals will have to survive a stern test, similar to that faced by their predecessors in the 27-year hunt for Dadua.

Celebrations after the dreaded dacoit's death gave way to tension and fear of retribution from other dacoit gangs in the mountainous Vindhya ranges on the southern fringes of Uttar Pradesh. But there is no denying that



"Dadua had distorted the state machinery and its democratic and political system."

AMITABH YASH, STF SSP